

Education

UNIVERSITY OF THE WEST INDIES GLOBAL CAMPUS

Bachelor of Science (B.Sc.), Psychology. GPA: 3.9/4.3 - First Class Honours

Awards: National Bursary Award: Academic Distinction, Distinction in Legal Analysis (CFBC, Year 2)

Research Interests: Emotion–Cognition Interaction; Metacognitive Dissonance; Human–AI Trust and Bias; Explainable AI (XAI); Experimental and Computational Behavioral Science

Research Experience

University of the West Indies

Research Study/ Practicum - Supervisor: Dr. Florence Seemungal

“Examining the Relationship between Faculty Support and Academic Self-Efficacy among Caribbean UWI Global Campus Students”

January 2024–

March 2025

- Co-authored research paper and conducted a structured quantitative investigation with UWI students, applying Bandura’s Social Cognitive Theory to examine the influence of faculty support on academic self-efficacy. Maintained methodological rigor through psychometrically validated instruments (Cronbach’s $\alpha > .80$) under JASP multiple regression analysis.

Independent Research Initiative- Emotion Encoded

Founder & Principal Researcher

June 2025- Present

St.Kitts & Nevis

- Independently conceptualized, designed and executed mixed-methods studies (N≈133+) investigating how emotional reasoning, heuristics, metacognition, and cognitive bias drive psychological resistance to Artificial Intelligence in high-stakes fields (medicine, law, finance) in the Caribbean. Findings from logistic regression modeling (Python, using pandas, matplotlib, seaborn) revealed agency bias, metacognitive dissonance & affective heuristics as dominant predictors of AI trust (OR=2.96, trend-level significance).
- Research findings were formally cited in a Ministry of Education national policy proposal on digital literacy and AI ethics, potentially impacting over 3,000 students. Secured \$700 USD in initial microgrant funding to establish an AI Tools Micro-Grant Program, equipping entrepreneurs with ethical AI access and support.
- Conducted an extensive professional interview series (N≈50+), performing thematic and semantic analyses of experts, including surgeons, anesthesiologists, oncologists, radiologists, cardiologists, founders of tele-health and behavioural science startups, physicians in internal medicine, attorneys-at-law, a biomedical engineering professor of Johns Hopkins University, and psychologists in Caribbean region to identify conditional acceptance, accountability ambiguity, and perceived threat to expertise as core cognitive-emotional barriers to professional AI adoption

- Preprint on PsyArXiv: Independent research paper, "The Cognitive Foundations of Algorithmic Trust: Human Reasoning in High-Stakes AI Systems," accepted and available on the psychology preprint server.
- Authored and published 60 + open-access briefs (e.g., “AI Therapists vs. Financial Advisors: Cognitive-Emotional Divides in Trust”) on website fostering public literacy on decoding emotional barriers to AI adoption.

Stanford University -School of Medicine | Stanford Digital Medic- / Global Health Innovation Research Collaborative Partnership & Co Author

March 2026 – Present

- Invited by Stanford School of Medicine to incorporate Emotion Encoded’s proprietary Caribbean physician insights into a Global AI Literacy and Implementation Open-access Curriculum for clinicians using AI , having been formally requested by faculty .
- **Collaborative Partnership:** Facilitated institutional integration and adoption of findings into a curriculum to establish a permanent case study for clinical AI implementation, hosted publicly at []
- Provided localized qualitative datasets and thematic analyses to architect frameworks for calibrating human-AI trust among medical specialists, translating regional data into scalable insights for clinical automation and global health delivery within resource-constrained environment
- Formulated the international distribution framework and scaling the curriculum directly to global medical faculties, universities, ministries and departments of health.
- Co-authoring a first-author peer-reviewed manuscript with Stanford Faculty and research scholar on Caribbean physician perspectives on clinical AI trust

University of Chicago Booth School of Business : Research Assistant (Remote)

Supervisor: Dr. Joshua Jackson (University of Chicago/ Harvard University)

March 2026 – Present

- Collaborated on a computational social science study analyzing public attitudes toward AI using Reddit discourse datasets.
- Quantitative Data Analysis: Categorized a 101-row dataset of AI-focused subreddits using a multi-class taxonomy and binary coding to provide the structural framework for a study on evolving AI discourse.

Research Consultant***UNDP Small Grants Programme Funded Initiative Apiculture & Climate Adaptation Project***

St.Kitts & Nevis
October 2025

- Provided behavioral research consulting for a USD \$74,000 UNDP-funded national apiculture initiative supporting climate resilience in rural farming communities.
- Pioneered conceptual frameworks and behavioural experiments to examine farmer engagement, sustainability mindsets, and adaptation behavior in small-island contexts.

Research Volunteer***UNESCO National Commission & Department of Culture Project***

St.Kitts & Nevis
August 2025 – March 2026

- Assisted in the comprehensive qualitative documentation and narrative synthesis for a UNESCO 10,000 USD funded Cultural heritage application project
- Conducted ethnographic fieldwork with 3 performance groups (N = 50+ masqueraders), including participant observation and semi-structured interviews, transcription, thematic coding, authoring the final scholarly narrative and guiding multi-media teams to ensure factual, conceptual and ethical coherence across all written and visual documentation.

Lead Researcher***Emotion Encoded & Mental Health Association of St. Kitts & Nevis***

St.Kitts & Nevis
October 2025- Present

- Leading a national experimental and mixed-methods study investigating behavioural, cognitive, and systemic determinants of counselling uptake among 100+ healthcare providers.
- Secured institutional approval by pitching the study's methodology and implementation plan to the Association's board.
- Designed and validated psychometrically robust instruments examining decision-making, perceived barriers, and behavioural correlates of mental health referrals and applied behavioural economics and cost-effectiveness model evaluating insurer-funded counselling coverage within the St. Kitts National Insurance framework.
- Findings will be cited in a 2026 National Policy Brief to inform sustainable health financing and national strategic planning.

PUBLICATIONS

Watts, S. (2025, October). *The Cognitive Foundations of Algorithmic Trust: Human Reasoning in High-Stakes AI Systems*. [Preprint]. PsyArXiv, Center for Open Science.
https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/jw36n_v2

Accepted as an independent researcher based in St. Kitts and Nevis.

Watts, S. (2025). Poster and video presentation submitted for review at the ACM Conference on Intelligent User Interfaces (IUI 2026), Paphos, Cyprus.

Watts, S., Pickering, A., & Aranda, Z. (2026) (In preparation). *AI-supported clinical decision-making: Perspectives of Caribbean medical professionals*. Collaborative research project, Stanford School of Medicine.

Leadership and Activities

Eastern Caribbean Central Bank- Summer Generative AI & Python Camp
Peer Mentor & Volunteer Instructor

St.Kitts & Nevis
July 2025- August 2025

- Designed an interactive Python “treasure-hunt” module
- Mentored 50 + youth in coding fundamentals, AI ethics, and algorithmic bias.

Emotion Encoded- AI Small Business Innovation Project
Founder & Project Lead

St.Kitts & Nevis
August 2025- Present

- Established and actively scaled outreach through partnerships with local innovation hubs and community organizations, institutionalizing inclusive innovation and advancing ethical AI literacy and human-centered practices among women and youth entrepreneurs in small enterprise development.

Skills & Interest

Research and Analytical Skills (Improving)

- Quantitative & Statistical Analysis: Logistic regression, multivariate analysis, experimental/survey design, psychometric scaling, inferential statistics. (JASP, SPSS)
- Data Science & Programming: Python (pandas, NumPy, matplotlib, seaborn, statsmodels), SQL, data cleaning, visualization, reproducible research workflows.
- Qualitative & Mixed Methods: Thematic & semantic analysis, grounded theory, interview coding, cross-method triangulation, integration of qualitative insights with statistical modeling.
- Research Design & Competencies: Hypothesis testing, model interpretation/validation, effect size estimation, reliability analysis (Cronbach’s alpha), data mapping/transformation.

Certifications (In Progress, 2025)

- Stanford Machine Learning (Andrew Ng, Coursera)
- IBM Data Science Professional Certificate

